

Gidgee Skink Care Guide

Egernia stokesii

Red Rocks Exotic Reptiles · Reviewed October 2026 · Version 2.0

Secure crevices, a broad basking surface and a plant-rich adult diet support natural behavior. Research documents stable family groups in the wild, but unfamiliar captive animals cannot be assumed to form a compatible group.

Species Profile

Common name: Gidgee Skink

Scientific name: *Egernia stokesii*

Adult size: 7-12 in (18-30 cm) total length; subspecies varies

Captive lifespan: 15-20 years or longer; not a statistical average. Typical captive lifespan is a planning estimate, not a measured statistical average.

Native range: Australia; range and microhabitat vary by subspecies

Habitat and activity: Diurnal; rocky crevices and dry woodland; documented stable family groups

Diet: Plant-rich omnivorous diet with varied insects

Care difficulty: Intermediate

Shopping List

- Secure enclosure at least 48 × 24 × 24 in (122 × 61 × 61 cm; L × W × H) for one adult; see Housing for exceptions and group arrangements.
- Digital thermometers for different zones; a suitable hygrometer; timer for a consistent day/night cycle.
- Species-appropriate substrate and multiple stable hides or covered retreats.
- Reliable supply of the staple foods described below, clean feeding tools and a transport container.
- Appropriate overhead heat source if required, controlled by a compatible thermostat; infrared thermometer for surfaces.
- Appropriate visible lighting and, where recommended below, a linear UVB fixture with measured shade and exposure zones.
- Fresh-water dish or cup; insect supplements when applicable; a scale appropriate to the animal's size.

Housing

Our recommended starting adult enclosure is 48 × 24 × 24 in (122 × 61 × 61 cm; L × W × H) for one animal. Larger usable space is encouraged. These dimensions are a husbandry recommendation, not a species-specific experimentally proven threshold.

Provide multiple hides across the warm-to-cool and moist-to-drier gradient, covered travel routes and species-appropriate burrowing or low climbing structure. Fix heavy decor to the floor before adding loose substrate so digging cannot undermine it.

Juveniles may use a furnished adult enclosure when food intake, hydration and waste can be monitored. A temporary grow-out enclosure should still offer choice and cover. Quarantine newcomers separately

with dedicated tools and a substrate that permits health monitoring; arrange veterinary assessment for unknown-origin animals.

Lighting & UVB

Provide roughly 10-12 hours of visible daylight followed by darkness. A measured UV Index (UVI) around 2.0-3.0 at the most exposed usable site, declining to near zero inside retreats, is our conservative starting recommendation. UVB and bright daytime illumination are recommended for routine care. These working UVI targets are not a claim that a controlled dose trial exists for every species.

Measure exposure at the animal's back height with an appropriate UVI meter, such as a Solarmeter 6.5. Lamp percentage, wattage and a fixed distance alone do not establish exposure: reflectors, mesh, perch height, plant growth and lamp age change output. Keep glass/plastic out of the UV path, follow fixture safety instructions and provide complete shade. Replace or reassess lamps according to measured output and manufacturer guidance.

Heating & Temperature

- Localized basking surface: 105-115°F (41-46°C).
- Cool-zone air: 75-82°F (24-28°C).
- Nighttime air: 68-75°F (20-24°C) for healthy established animals.

Create the gradient on one side rather than heating every hide to the same temperature. Use a compatible thermostat on each heat source; a manual lamp dimmer does not replace thermostatic protection. Secure the probe and verify temperatures independently: probe thermometers measure air/retreat temperature, while an infrared thermometer measures exposed surfaces.

Use appropriately guarded overhead warmth when needed. Keep animals clear of hot fixtures, avoid heat rocks, and switch visible lights off at night. Night heat is needed only when the room falls below the appropriate range; use a thermostat-controlled lightless source if necessary.

Humidity & Ventilation

30-50% ambient with a humid crevice/refuge. Treat readings as a starting pattern rather than a number to chase regardless of substrate, airflow or animal behavior.

Measure humidity in a representative occupied zone, away from a freshly sprayed surface. Provide sheltered moisture choices while retaining airflow. Persistent condensation, sour odor, flooded soil or surfaces that never dry indicate a setup problem. Ventilation and hydration must be adjusted together rather than simply sealing all vents.

Water & Hydration

Provide a clean, appropriately shallow dish or accessible elevated water cup at all times. Change it daily and immediately when soiled; wash it regularly with dedicated tools. Potable water is generally suitable, with treatment where local water quality requires it.

For animals that drink droplets, mist foliage or suitable surfaces at the time they become active, then allow partial drying. Droplets supplement the dish; water chemistry claims should be based on evidence rather than a species' trade name.

Substrate

A naturalistic substrate helps hold some humidity, cushions the animal, and allows digging or burrow use. A good DIY substrate is 60% organic topsoil and 40% play sand, packed at least 4" deep.

The substrate should be dry to slightly moist in most areas, with a more humid area under the cool-side hide. Avoid keeping the entire enclosure wet, as this is not a tropical species.

Feces and urates should be removed daily, and contaminated substrate should be scooped out and replaced. The substrate should be completely replaced every 3-4 months in a non-bioactive setup, or as needed based on smell, moisture, and cleanliness.

Food & Feeding

Gidgee skinks are omnivores. Adult diets should emphasize leafy plant foods with a smaller varied invertebrate component, rather than using insects as the sole or dominant adult staple. Research on *E. stokesii badia* supports a substantial plant contribution and age-related diet differences; locality and subspecies should still be considered.

Offer chopped collard, mustard, turnip and dandelion greens, endive, escarole, cactus pad and suitable vegetables. Use gut-loaded crickets, roaches, silkworms and other cultured feeders as measured protein meals. Fruit and fatty larvae are occasional extras, not a diet base.

Offer fresh plant food most days. Growing juveniles may need small insect meals 3-5 times weekly; adults often need insects only 1-2 times weekly alongside plants. These are starting frequencies, not validated prescriptions: adjust portions to growth, reproductive state, weight and condition, and remove leftovers.

Supplements

Lightly dust appropriate insect meals with calcium and use a balanced reptile multivitamin containing suitable vitamin A according to the product's directions. Gut-loading and variety support nutrition but do not eliminate the need to balance calcium-poor prey.

Match D3 supplementation to the actual UVB exposure and to vitamins already included in other products. UVB does not automatically mean zero dietary D3, and lack of UVB does not justify unlimited D3. Follow one coherent program; do not combine multiple strong vitamin products or coat every feeder heavily.

Decor & Enrichment

Decorations are a core part of gidgee skink care. This species needs tight crevices, sturdy basking sites, and climbing opportunities. Good decor can include rock stacks, cork rounds, cork flats, branches, hollow logs, textured backgrounds, ledges, and artificial or live plants.

Any rocks or heavy decor must be placed securely so the skink cannot dig underneath and cause a collapse. Place heavy structures directly on the enclosure floor before adding substrate, or secure them so they cannot shift.

Handling & Behavior

Let the animal settle and feed consistently before brief optional handling. Support the body, work low over a safe surface and stop when repeated retreat, escape attempts or defensive behavior show stress. Never lift a lizard by its tail.

Avoid handling immediately after meals, during difficult sheds or when unwell. Wash hands and use dedicated equipment to reduce disease transfer.

Cleaning & Routine Maintenance

Daily: check the animal's access to water/appropriate moisture, temperatures, visible condition and equipment. Remove feces, contaminated material, dead feeders and spoiled food promptly.

Regularly: clean dishes and feeding surfaces, check thermostats and probes, inspect decor stability and maintain ventilation. Bioactive systems still require waste checks, food removal, plant care and drainage maintenance; they are not self-cleaning.

Record appetite, activity, shed/molt history and weight or body condition when safe. Arrange veterinary assessment for unexplained changes. Quarantine new animals with dedicated tools, and disinfect only with a suitable product used at the label dilution/contact time, then rinse and dry as required before return.

Cohabitation

Wild gidgee skinks form stable social/family groups. An established compatible pair or family group may be maintained by an experienced keeper in substantially larger housing with several crevices, basking choices and feeding sites. Introducing unrelated animals can cause serious aggression. Do not automatically separate a stable family solely because solitary housing is simpler, but keep backup enclosures and monitor each animal.

Shedding, Molting & Seasonal Changes

Maintain access to a clean humid retreat and inspect toes, tail tip and eyes after shedding when observation is possible. Do not peel retained skin or apply oils/adhesives. Persistent constriction, damaged tissue or repeated failed sheds warrants veterinary help.

Seasonal changes in appetite or activity can occur. Check temperatures, hydration and weight before treating prolonged refusal as normal. Deliberate brumation or breeding cycles require healthy animals and species-specific preparation; pet care does not require forcing a seasonal shutdown.

Reproduction

Gidgee skinks give birth to live young and show family-associated social behavior. Plan breeding around a compatible established group, female condition and substantial space. Do not assume every newborn can remain safely in every captive group; assess feeding access, aggression and the needs of vulnerable offspring.

Common Health Concerns

- Poor body condition or feeding decline: check the full gradient, hydration and food quality; arrange assessment for persistent refusal accompanied by weight loss.

- Calcium/vitamin imbalance: weakness, tremors, a soft or misshapen jaw or abnormal limbs require veterinary assessment; extra high-dose supplements are not a substitute for diagnosis.
- Skin, shed or injury problems: repeated retained skin, wounds, swelling or abnormal discoloration deserve prompt attention.
- Respiratory or systemic illness: labored/open-mouth breathing at rest, marked lethargy, loss of balance, persistent diarrhea or rapid deterioration require an experienced exotic veterinarian.

Sources & Review Information

Reviewed October 2026 · RRE version 2.0. Care targets are practical starting recommendations informed by natural history, published work and captive experience. For less-studied species, enclosure dimensions, feeding frequencies, UVI ranges and lifespan estimates are not experimentally validated universal thresholds. Adjust for the individual, locality, life stage and veterinary advice.

The Reptile Database. Species taxonomy, distribution and cited natural-history literature.
<https://reptile-database.reptarium.cz/Egernia/stokesii>

Baines et al. (2016). The UV-Tool: choosing UV gradients using natural history and behavior. General lighting framework; not a species-specific dose trial.
<https://doi.org/10.19227/jzar.v4i1.150>

Gardner et al. (2002). Stable social aggregations in *Egernia stokesii*.
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/12435097/>

Bradley and colleagues (2023). Ecological considerations for *Egernia stokesii badia*, including diet and ontogenetic differences. Extrapolation across subspecies needs care.
<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC10451732/>